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pandemic... Our operating margin improved by about 800 basis points. That is why, since I came in, HUL's market cap has grown from about \$16 billion to \$70 billion. It has been a quantum shift. There are two key parameters to judge it. Today, our market share is one of the strongest we have enjoyed in many years. And second, the increase in turnover [we] managed in the last 10 years is greater than the total turnover of any other FMCG company in the country.

India is such an attractive consumer market that new players will come in. I believe, competitors are good for the consumers and they are good for a company like HUL too—because they bring the best out of us. If we did not have good competition, we would have become complacent. Competitors keep us on our toes.

Q: How will HUL survive the onslaught, given that competitors are getting more aggressive?

A: The per capita consumption of FMCG products in India is about 40 tonnes, which is half of the average for Asia, one-third of China's and in comparison to the Philippines it, is one-fourth. Therefore, the headroom to grow in this market continues to be massive. However, apart from the potential of the India market, what keeps me optimistic about a brighter future for HUL are three key factors. First is our portfolio. We have done a lot of work to make our portfolio future-ready by expanding into newer categories, segments and adjacencies and investing significantly in growing the pie through market development. The second factor is talent. We are still the employer of choice in this country... when we go to the IIMs, we recruit the best possible talent. Then we have the most rigorous programmes to sharpen them. We get the best and we make them better. That is the reason why we still maintain the tag of being 'the CEO factory'.

Third is our capability. We have invested significant amounts of money and talent in re-imagining HUL. Our vision is very clear: we want to be the most intelligent consumer goods enterprise. We started re-imagining HUL six years back. We are working across the value chain, by further digitising it, bringing in robots, by implementing AI tools. The HUL of tomorrow is going to be significantly different from the HUL of the past.

India is not a zero-sum game. If some company is making an additional say ₹300 crore, that does not mean it is going to cost HUL ₹300 crore. This year, we are adding ₹5,000 crore to our top line. These together make me confident that HUL has an amazing future ahead.

Q: What do you envisage as the HUL of tomorrow?

A: The business of FMCG is undergoing a major transformation. Earlier, we used to procure raw materials, produce goods at scale to keep the costs down, reach as many outlets as possible and create market pull through promotions. That is how the FMCG system used to work. Now we are in the process of being an intelligent enterprise, creating ecosystems involving consumers and operations where data and technology take centre stage. Today, our Shikhar app that we benchmark has over 700,000 customers (retail partners). So even when a sales representative does not visit stores, retailers can place orders any time they choose... Our tie-up with State Bank of India ensures that retailers get paperless credit from the lender, using the app.

There was a time, when we used to do a huge amount of consumer research (physically) to gauge what the consumer needs, following which our R&D teams would create prototypes, then we [would] test them out and do commercial runs, etc. Today, at our innovation